

WEEK 4 LESSON GUIDE

**STICK
TOGETHER**

BIG IDEA

You'll always have a friend in Jesus.

BIBLE

Proverbs 18:24; John 15:13–16, 18:2–27; Psalm 113:4–8

ABOUT THIS WEEK

Great adventure stories tell about friends who have each other's backs and stick together no matter what. This week, we'll see how Jesus calls us to love others the way he loves us and how God's faithfulness is the ultimate example of an unshakable friend. Jesus chose us to be his friends, and that means no matter what, **you'll always have a friend in Jesus!**

WHAT? What are we talking about?



See the
Accessibility Hacks



ACTIVITY | Jungle of Doom

- Welcome to our final week of *Stick Together*—a series all about friendship, and a little bit of adventure too.
- Think about your favorite adventure stories—like *Jumanji*, *Indiana Jones*, or even *Jungle Cruise*. The danger is real, the challenges are wild, and the stakes are high. It's not the kind of situation you want to be in alone.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** For this activity, you'll need [fake tropical plants](#), [jungle-themed props](#), [safari hats](#), [animal costumes](#), a bunch of [giant beach balls](#), cardboard boxes, and [masking tape](#). Before your teaching time, use the tape to block out a pathway from one end of your room to the other. Set up plants and cardboard boxes on and along the path as obstacles or barriers to hide behind. (If you're feeling extra, try spray-painting your giant beach balls to look like Indiana-Jones-style boulders.) Call a group of students to the front to play. One person will be the lone hero (give them a safari hat to wear), and the rest will be animals (give them costumes) or boulder-rollers. To play, have your hero try to make it from one end of the path to the other, while the boulder-rollers roll beach balls at them and the animals dart out in front of them. To keep the game somewhat competitive, limit your boulder-rollers and animals to only one roll or sprint each, or have them only move in a straight line across the path, like a game of [Frogger](#). Play for as many rounds, and with as many students, as you'd like.
- Okay, maybe sometimes it's kind of fun to go at something alone. In a game, it might be a fun challenge when...
 - Everyone's out to get you!
 - There's no one else on your team!
 - It's you against the world!
- But in real life, I think we'd all prefer to have at least one real friend on our side—especially when life gets tough.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.*
 - **If you could be best friends with any movie character, who would you pick and why?**
 - **How would you describe your ideal friendship?**

QUESTION | Good Friendships Brainstorm (Part 1)

- For the last few weeks, we've been talking about how to find good friends and how to be good friends. Last week, we even brainstormed some of the qualities of a good friend. But today I want to talk about what a good *friendship* looks like.
- When you're in a good friendship...
 - You spend time together.
 - You're honest with each other.
 - You can talk to each other about anything.
 - You just *get* each other.
 - **What else? What does a good friendship look like?**
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Bring out the same board you used last week to brainstorm the qualities of a good friend. Then bring out a second matching board. This time, brainstorm what makes a good friendship.*
- We might be able to describe what a good friend looks like, or how a good friendship works, but experiencing a good friendship in real life isn't always that easy.



See the Hacks



VIDEO | A Clip From *The Jungle Book*

- For the last few weeks, we've been watching clips from adventure movies because there's usually some kind of friend who shows up and helps our hero complete their quest or escape danger. But sometimes in these stories, we also get to see what it's like for a character to not have anyone to turn to at all.
- Has anyone ever seen *The Jungle Book*? If you have, you might picture the scenes of little Mowgli dancing alongside his buddy Baloo. But although friendship happens eventually in this movie, it doesn't start out that way.
 - When Mowgli is just a baby, his parents are tragically killed.
 - He's adopted by a pack of wolves who love him as one of their own... for a while. But as Mowgli gets older, a bloodthirsty tiger threatens to kill Mowgli and any wolves who try to protect him.
 - So when Mowgli is still just a kid, the wolves have to decide: Is Mowgli worth the risk?
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *As a teaching tool, play a short clip like [this one](#) (0:55–2:15) from *The Jungle Book*. [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!*
- Ultimately, the wolves decide Mowgli is too much of a risk and is no longer welcome in their pack. Suddenly, Mowgli's life looks a lot different than he thought it would. Suddenly, he's betrayed, abandoned, and alone.

- We've all had moments like this, haven't we? We all know what it's like when...
 - The friendships we thought we'd make never happen.
 - The people we thought would be there for us, aren't.
 - The people we thought would defend us, don't.
 - The people we thought would never leave, do.
- It hurts to feel alone, invisible, or abandoned. Don't we all want at least one friend who never leaves?

SO WHAT? Why does it matter to God and to us?



See the Middle
School Hacks



STORY | Talk about a time life felt lonely.

- Can I be real with you? There have been times when I've felt pretty friendless. Sometimes even when I had "friends," I still felt like I had no one who really understood or cared about the real me.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Tell a story (or ask a volunteer or student to tell a story) about a time you felt alone, abandoned, misunderstood, or friendless, preferably when you were a teenager. Don't resolve the story just yet, but be vulnerable and real about how you were feeling.
- Those times were really difficult for me. Maybe times are difficult for you right now. It's not always easy to know what to do or who to turn to when we feel that way. Difficult times may make you hesitant to trust anyone ever again. It makes sense to feel unsure about who will be there for you when others have let you down.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - **Raise your hand if you've ever felt a little bit alone or friendless. How does it feel to know you're not the only one?**
 - *** When you felt that way, what do you think you needed most from other people?**



See the High
School Hacks



SCRIPTURE | Proverbs 18:24

- Of course, if you're going through a hard time, I'm always going to suggest you open up the Bible to see what God has to say. For the last few weeks, we've been looking at the book of Proverbs because it's packed with helpful wisdom about issues we all face, like friendship.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Read Proverbs 18:24.
- If I'd read this verse in Proverbs at the point in my life that I just told you about, I would have been pretty confused. You might have heard me yelling, "What friend? Where are they? Who are they?" So if this verse seems unlikely to you, I get it!
 - But let me tell you about something God showed me during those hard times that makes this verse make a lot more sense. Sometimes, those really difficult and lonely times actually help me know Jesus better.

- When all the usual support falls apart, when friends don't call back, when someone turns their back on you, or you feel alone, you really do have someone "sticking" with you.

SCRIPTURE | John 18:2–27

- Jesus knew a thing or two about being abandoned, betrayed, and left all alone. If you know the story of Jesus' death, you know Jesus knew everything that was about to happen in advance. He knew his best friends would betray him, that he would walk to his death all alone, and that he would suffer and die.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Read or summarize John 18:2–27, highlighting the moments when people betrayed or hurt Jesus.*
- First, Judas—one of Jesus' disciples—shows up with a group of soldiers and betrays Jesus with a kiss and a bargain, handing Him over for a bag of silver, pretending to be loyal while giving Him up. Ouch. Then, Peter—the guy who swore he'd never leave Jesus—denies he knows him. Not once. Three times.
- Two friends. Two breakdowns. One hurting Jesus. But what does Jesus do? He doesn't write them off. The rest of this story shows us something wild: Jesus stays faithful even when his friends don't. He's not like the people who gave up on you. He's the kind of friend who sticks with you, even when things fall apart.
- These stories don't show the disciples at their best, do they? But they do show us exactly what kind of friend Jesus is. Can you see the contrast between human weakness and Jesus?
 - Judas betrays Jesus to gain something for himself. Jesus selflessly offers his life for others.
 - Peter denies knowing Jesus to protect himself. Jesus stays to protect others.
 - The disciples' loyalty crumbles under pressure. Jesus' loyalty endures.
 - The crowd demands Jesus' death. Jesus chooses to give them life.
 - The disciples abandon Jesus in fear. Jesus never gives up on his friends.
- This is the friendship Jesus offers you. It's not a flaky kind of friendship. It's the kind of friendship that sees both the good and the broken in you, and stays anyway. Jesus is the kind of friend who lays everything down so you'll never have to wonder if you're alone.

SCRIPTURE | John 15:13–16

- Hours before everything turned for the worse, when Jesus already knew he was only hours away from being betrayed, arrested, and killed, listen to what he said to his followers.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** *Read John 15:13–16.*
- Jesus wanted them to know...
 - "You're my friends."
 - "I love you."
 - "I chose you."
 - "Everything that's mine is yours."
 - "I'll always hear you when you call."



See the Hacks



- "I never want you to feel alone or afraid. I want you to know how loved you are."

VIDEO | A Clip From *The Jungle Book*

- Remember that movie scene we watched earlier? There's a moment I didn't show you. It's the moment when Mowgli decides to leave his wolf pack of his own free will, rather than experiencing the heartbreak of being told to leave.
- As he leaves his wolf pack for what he is sure is the last time, here's what his mother wolf had to say...
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** As a teaching tool, play a short clip like [this one](#) (3:10–4:00) from *The Jungle Book*. [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes!
- "You're mine," she said. "No matter where you go, you will always be mine." I wonder if this is what it was like when Jesus was talking to his friends for one of the last times before his death. "You're mine. No matter what happens, I'm not going anywhere."

See the Middle
School Hacks

STORY | Talk about a time you found friendship in Jesus.

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Earlier you told a story about a time you felt alone, abandoned, misunderstood. Continue sharing by talking about a time when Jesus showed up for you in a way like no friend could.
- It's hard to feel like we have unreliable or nonexistent friends. Even Jesus knows what it's like to be sold out, talked about, disregarded, and ignored.
- But in my loneliest moments, I also know what it's like for Jesus to show up for me in ways no friend ever could.
 - He's a friend who understands the pain I'm going through because he's been through even worse.
 - He's a friend who won't give up on me, even when I try giving up on him.
 - He's a friend who gave everything for me, even his life.
- In Jesus, I've found someone who knows and loves me better than anyone ever could. And the same is true for you, because **you'll always have a friend in Jesus.**

NOW WHAT? What does God want us to do about it?

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - **On a scale of 1–5, how difficult is it for you to see Jesus as your friend? Why do you feel that way?**
 - *** In what ways has Jesus been a friend to you in the past?**
 - *** In what ways do you think Jesus wants to be a friend to you now?**



Spend Time
With God



QUESTION | Good Friendships Brainstorm (Part 2)

- Maybe it's hard to imagine being friends with a person you can't see, hear, hug, or high-five. But since we've already come up with what a good friendship looks like, let's see if a friendship with Jesus might have any similarities.
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Return to the boards you created earlier to share the qualities of a good friend and a good friendship. Choose a few cards to read out loud and then translate each one to show:
 - How Jesus is a good friend.
 - What it could look like to have a friendship with Jesus.
 - How we can hold up our end of the friendship.
- What if you could be friends with Jesus, not just as a religious idea, but in a real, personal, *I-know-you-and-you-know-me* way? Well, you can!



See the High
School Hacks



Spend Time
With others



MUSIC | "He Calls Me Friend" (Luminate House)

- But friendship doesn't just happen—it's something you build. And just like any other friendship, your friendship with Jesus will grow when you invest in it.
 - **TALK TO JESUS:** You don't have to impress Jesus with fancy prayers. Just talk to him. Get to know him. Show him the real you.
 - **SPEND TIME WITH JESUS:** Friendships grow when you spend time together. Try spending five minutes reading a story about Jesus in the Gospels. Watch how Jesus treats people. You'll see he's kind, patient, and available.
 - **BE A GOOD FRIEND:** Be the kind of friend Jesus is to you. If he's loyal, forgiving, and shows up when it matters most, how can you reflect that back to him? How can you reflect that back to others, who he loves and calls his friends too?
- **INSTRUCTIONS:** Play the song "[He Calls Me Friend](#)" (Luminate House), but make sure you have purchased any required licenses. [Read this](#) for more information on legally using copyrighted material for educational purposes! As you play the song, invite your students to spend time with Jesus.

DISCUSSION

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** If you have more than 15 students, skip this discussion and save it for small groups. If you conduct this discussion, the starred questions are designed for high schoolers, so you may want to skip them for middle schoolers.
 - **Read Psalm 113:4–8.** What does this passage tell us about God? What does it tell us about how God feels about us?
 - * What do you think could change about your life and your faith if you really treated Jesus like your most trusted friend?
 - This week, what's one way you're going to invest in your friendship with Jesus?



See the
Accessibility Hacks



REFLECTION | Adventure Stations

- **INSTRUCTIONS:** For this activity, you'll need [blank index cards](#), [markers](#), [pens](#), [stickers](#), [small paper bags](#), and the [signs](#) provided in your Week 4 folder. Create three simple stations around the room to help students reflect on their friendship with Jesus in a different way. These stations can be done in any order and should take just a few minutes each. At each station, set out writing supplies and the signs with their instructions. At the end, have students gather all their reflection cards in a bag to take home and decorate them if they'd like.
- Remember, Jesus is the greatest friend you'll ever have, which means he's always available to you. So don't let your time with him end when you leave this room. Keep getting to know him. And, once you get to know him, make sure you stick together. Because **you'll always have a friend in Jesus.**